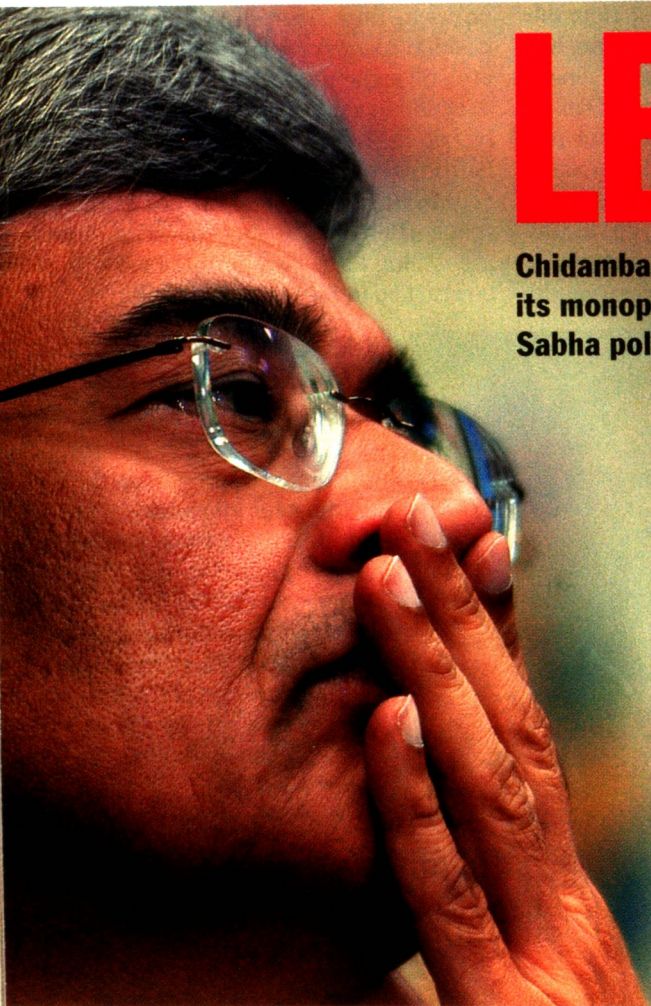


LEFT ALONE

Chidambaram's politically-correct Budget has robbed the Left of its monopoly over India Suffering . With less than a year for Lok Sabha polls, the Communists will have to cover much lost ground.



SUMIT INDER SINGH

■ By Satarupa Bhattacharjya

"He has announced everything but the election date."

CPI leader Gurudas Dasgupta shortly after Finance Minister P. Chidambaram unveiled the Union Budget on February 28.

Communists are not known to relish them and it is certain they will dread the next general elections, whenever they are held. Just three days before Chidambaram presented his fifth and this Government's final Budget, thousands of farmers were herded into Jantar Mantar—the hub of

dissent in Delhi—by UNPA, the latest aspirants for the Third Front space in India. Also present at the rally were CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat, his counterpart in CPI A.B. Bardhan and CPI(M) Politburo member Sitaram Yechury. The motley group had assembled to protest against what was being described as the betrayal of farmers by the Congress-led Government.

On February 28, Chidambaram unveiled the UPA Government's most popular policy statement by far. The cheers that greeted the finance minister from the Congress and UPA benches, when he announced the Rs 60,000 crore debt relief package for

SPEECHLESS: Congress has usurped Karat's agenda

nearly 4 crore farmers, raised the decibel levels in the high-domed Lower House to new highs. But the celebrations did not spill over to the benches occupied by the 59 Left MPs, mostly from Kerala and West Bengal. It was perhaps the first open admission by the Communists that after four years, their world around Congress had collapsed.

Chidambaram's largesse had taken the wind out of the Left's sails. Its MPs wouldn't bring themselves to admit that their monopoly over India Suffering had been brought to an end. But panic buttons are being pressed in AKG and Ajoy Bhavans after the

If money grew on trees...
gardening would be the most respected profession.